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California advances two bills recognizing Jewish ethnicity, protecting community - If passed, both bills could be enacted into law by the end of August.

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Two bills sponsored by Jewish California (formerly the Jewish Public Affairs Committee of California) passed through their final policy committees on Tuesday and are set to be heard by the state senate in August.

SB 1387 – Recognizing Jewish ethnicity in state law, data

The first of the two bills, SB 1387, authored by Democratic Senator Henry Stern, concerns the recognition of Jewish ethnicity in California state law and in data collection.

The majority of US Jews cite ancestry and culture as being central to their Jewish identity, according to Jewish California, citing the Pew Research Center. Only 36% say that the Jewish religion is central to their identity. This identity gap, according to Jewish California, leads to undercounting, misclassification, and misunderstanding of California's Jewish population.

For this reason, bill SB 1387 requires that all of the state's ethnicity data collection systems include "Jewish" as an ethnicity option, not only as a religious identifier.

"For years, California has recognized that good data drives good policy – and has extended that recognition to community after community," said David Bocarsly, CEO of Jewish California. "Jewish Californians deserve the same. This bill ensures our community is neither invisible nor misrepresented in the systems that shape public health, education, and civil rights decisions."

SB 1387 will next be heard in the Assembly Appropriations Committee in August. If passed, it will be voted on by the full California State Legislature by the end of August. Should SB 1387 be enacted, the State of California would become the first state in the US to recognize Jewish identity as an ethnicity.

AB 1836 – Securing community events against hate

The second bill, AB 1836, was authored by Democratic Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel and co-sponsored by Jewish California and Equality California, an LGBTQ+ civil rights organization.

AB 1836 broadens the scope of the current California State Nonprofit Security Grant Program (CSNSGP). Currently, funds granted by the CSNSGP can be used to bolster security at a non-profit's permanent facility and for the people within it.

AB 1836 allows for the funds to be used to secure off-site events as well, including religious observances, LGBTQ+ Pride events, cultural festivals, marches, and protests. The bill would also ensure that eligible nonprofits without a permanent physical location are eligible for funding.

"Our communities don't just gather behind security doors – we gather for religious holidays in the park, we demonstrate, and we host public festivals and parades," said CEO Bocarsly.

"Vulnerable communities should not have to worry about safety when practicing our traditions in the community. But with hate-motivated violence on the rise, the cost of securing these gatherings has become prohibitive for many organizations, threatening the very community-building that defines us. We thank Assemblymember Gabriel for his leadership in solving this problem, and we're proud to work alongside Equality California to make sure every

Californian can come together without fear."

AB 1836 will next be heard in the Senate Appropriations Committee in August. Like SB 1387, if passed, it will also be voted on by the full California State Legislature by the end of August.

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